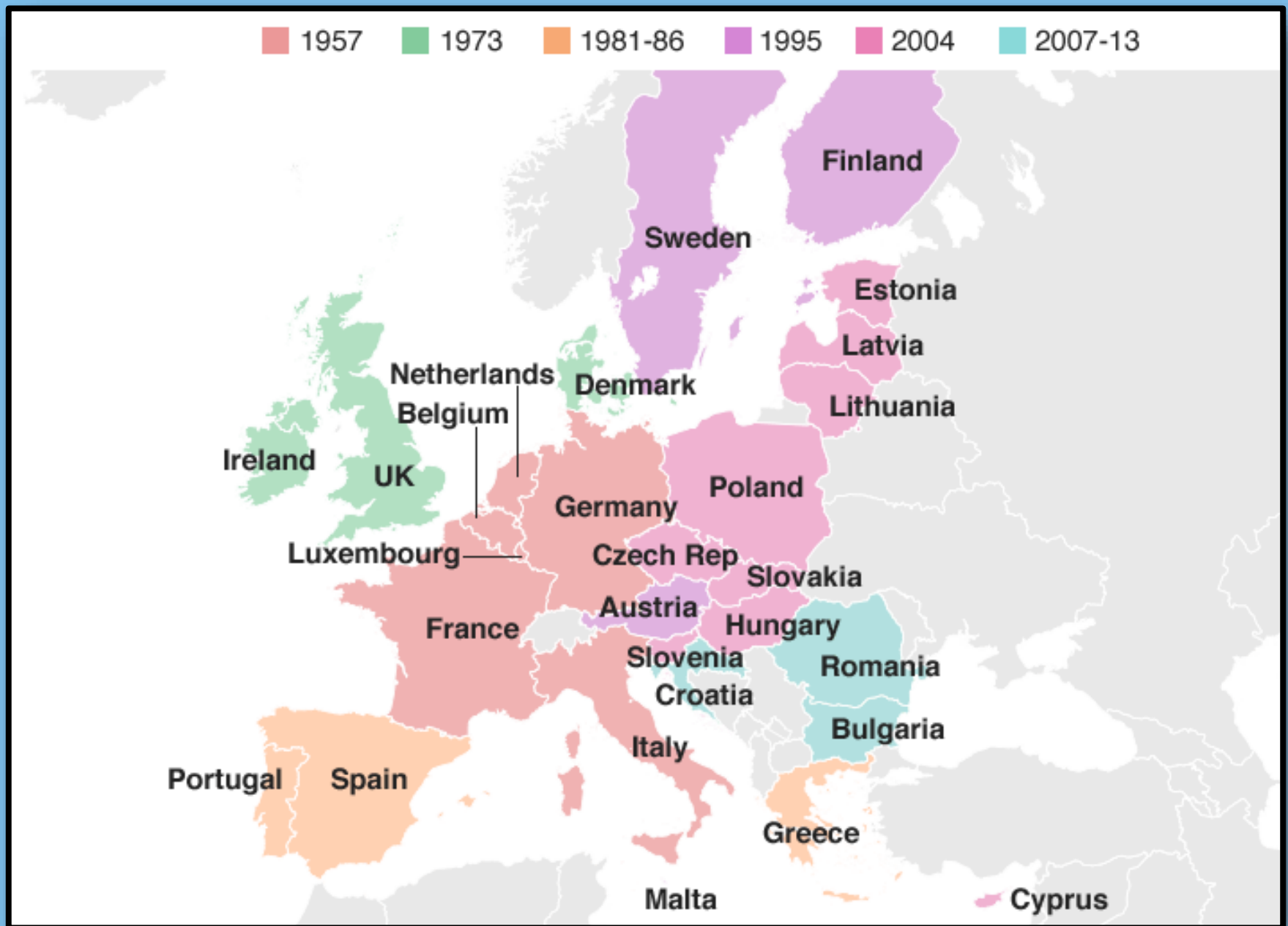


The
**EUROPEAN
UNION**

History

- The European Union (EU) is an economic and political partnership between many European countries.
- After WWII ended, France and Germany came up with a plan to ensure the countries would never go to war with each other again.
- The result was a deal signed by 6 countries in 1957.
- In 2019, the EU has grown to 28 members (with one in the process of leaving).



*The UK voted to withdraw from the EU in 2016.

The European Union flag was designed by Arsene Heitz and Paul Levy in 1955.



Purpose

- The European Union was originally established to set up free trade among member countries.
- Today, the EU is a powerful trade bloc that makes up 1/5th of the world's trade.
- Goods produced in Europe can move freely, without tariffs, to other European nations, which leads to huge cost savings to consumers and businesses.

Purpose

- Even though the EU's original purpose was to encourage free trade within Europe, it now has several other important interests:
 1. Creating a stable, peaceful relationship between countries
 2. Ensuring the safety and security of its members
 3. Promoting social issues like protecting human rights and preserving the environment
- The European Union members work together for advantages that would be out of their reach if each were working alone.

Together

- The EU believes that when countries work together they are a more powerful force in the world because they involve:
 - more money,
 - more people,
 - and more land areas.
- This helps make small countries more competitive in the world market.

- The US is much larger than separate European countries.
- When the EU countries combine, they have more people and a larger economy, and they can compete in a global economy.

	European Union	United States
Land Area	1,500,000	3,700,000
Population	513,000,000	329,000,000
Gross Domestic Product	\$15.65 trillion	\$15.29 trillion
GDP Per Capita	\$34,000	\$59,000

Benefits

- The EU has built a strong relationship among its member nations.
- Not having tariffs has led to improved trade and higher standards of living among members.
 - Wealthy countries are sharing wealth with poorer countries.
- Citizens are allowed to move freely among member countries in order to find better jobs.
- The EU's strict environmental standards have helped some countries improve their environment.





Euro Coins and Bills



EU Members

Austria	Belgium	Bulgaria	Croatia
Cyprus	Czech Republic	Denmark	Estonia
Finland	France	Germany	Greece
Hungary	Ireland	Italy	Latvia
Lithuania	Luxembourg	Malta	Netherlands
Poland	Portugal	Romania	Slovakia
Slovenia	Spain	Sweden	United Kingdom*

*Brexit: For the time being, the United Kingdom remains a member of the EU and rights and obligations continue to fully apply to the UK.

European Union Parliament Building in Strasbourg, France



European Union Parliament Building in Strasbourg, France



Brexit

- In June 2016, the people in the United Kingdom voted to leave the European Union.
- The people who voted “leave” say they want the UK to be less influenced by other countries and to have its own laws rather than having to go by the rules of the EU.
- They believed the UK was being held back by the EU, which they said imposed too many rules on business and charged billions of pounds a year in membership fees for little in return.



The UK's Prime Minister at the time, David Cameron, supported remaining part of the EU. When the country voted to leave, he decided to step down as the country's leader.

Brexit

- Brexit supporters also wanted the UK to take back full control of its borders and to reduce the number of people coming into the country to live and/or work.
- The UK will continue to abide by EU treaties and laws, but not take part in any decision-making, while it negotiates a withdrawal agreement and the terms of its relationship with the EU.

Update

- Because of conflicts over the withdrawal agreement, Brexit has been delayed many times over the past three years.
- As it stands now, the United Kingdom is officially due to leave the European Union on October 31, 2019 with a “transition period” that lasts until December 31, 2020.

Non-Members

- There are several other countries that are NOT EU members, including Turkey, Switzerland, Iceland, & Russia.
- WHY?
 1. Turkey's culture, stability, & location to the Middle East causes some EU members to not want Turkey to join.
 2. Switzerland has one of the world's highest standards of living & prefers its economy to not be regulated under the EU.
 3. The EU has strict limits on the fishing industry, & Iceland does not want the EU's control on its most important economic activity.
 4. Russia prefers to be an independent world leader over its own resources and economy.